The Spark Inside You – A Collection

By Susan Griffin and Clementine von Radics

INTRODUCTION

Throughout history, in every culture around the world, extraordinary women have pushed society to think bigger, move forward and create. Take a historical trip with me and I'll introduce you to a few examples of their ceaseless curiosity, boundless courage and world-changing resourcefulness. Thanks to each of them, women and girls all over the world are able to live with bigger dreams than ever before.

The Spark Inside You – A Compilation by Susan Griffin and Clementine von Radics

I Like to Think of Harriet Tubman by Susan Griffin

I like to think of Harriet Tubman.
Harriet Tubman who carried a revolver,
who had a scar on her head from a rock thrown
by a slave-master (because she
talked back) , and who
had a ransom on her head

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of thousands of dollars and who
was never caught, and who
had no use for the law
when the law was wrong,
who defied the law. I like
to think of her.
I like to think of her especially
when I think of the problem
of feeding children.

The legal answer
to the problem of feeding children
is ten free lunches every month,
being equal, in the child's real life,
to eating lunch every other day.
Monday but not Tuesday.
I like to think of the President
eating lunch on Monday, but not
Tuesday.
and when I think of the President
and the law, and the problem of
feeding children, I like to

think of Harriet Tubman
and her revolver.

And then sometimes
I think of the President
and other men,
men who practice the law,
who revere the law,
who make the law,
who enforce the law
who live behind
and operate through
and feed themselves
at the expense of
starving children
because of the law.

men who sit in paneled offices
and think about vacations
and tell women
whose care it is
to feed children

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not to be hysterical
not to be hysterical as in the word
hysterikos, the greek for
womb suffering,
not to suffer in their
wombs,
not to care,
not to bother the men
because they want to think
of other things
and do not want
to take women seriously.
I want them to think about Harriet Tubman,
and remember,
remember she was beaten by a white man
and she lived
and she lived to redress her grievances,
and she lived in swamps
and wore the clothes of a man
bringing hundreds of fugitives from
slavery, and was never caught,
and led an army,

and won a battle,

and defied the laws

because the laws were wrong, I want men

to take us seriously.

I am tired wanting them to think

about right and wrong.

I want them to fear.

I want them to feel fear now I want them

to know

that there is always a time

there is always a time to make right

what is wrong,

there is always a time

for retribution

and that time

is beginning.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier

For Teenage Girls with Wild Ambitions and Trembling Hearts by Clementine von Radics

[Anne Frank . . .]

When you are 13 years old,

the heat will be turned up too high

and the stars will not be in your favor.

You will hide behind a bookcase

with your family and everything left behind.

You will pour an ocean into a diary.

When they find you, you will be nothing

but a spark above a burning bush,

still, tell them

Despite everything, I really believe people are good at heart.

[Joan of Arc . . .]

When you are 14,

a voice will call you to greatness.

When the doubters call you crazy, do not listen.

They don't know the sound

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of their own God's whisper. Use your armor,
use your sword, use your two good hands.
Do not let their doubting
drown out the sound of your own heartbeat.
You are the Maid of Untamed Patriotism.
Born to lead armies into victory and unite a nation
like a broken heart.

[Malala . . .]
When you are 15, you will be punished
for learning too proudly. A man
will climb onto your school bus and insist
your sisters name you enemy.
When you do not hide,
he will point his gun at your temple
and fire three times. Three years later,
in an ocean of words, with no apologies,
you will stand before the leaders of the world
and tell them your country is burning.

[Mary Shelley . . .]
When you are 16 years old,

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you will invent science fiction.
The story of a man named Frankenstein
and his creation. Soon after you will learn
that little girls with big ideas are more terrifying
than monsters, but don't worry.
You will be remembered long after
they have put down their torches.

[Jackie Mitchell . . .]
When you are 17 years old,
you will strike out Babe Ruth and Lou Gehrig
one right after the other.
Men will be afraid of the lightening
in your fingertips. A few days later
you will be fired from the major leagues
because "Girls are too delicate to play baseball"

[Sacajawea . . .]
You will turn 18 with a baby on your back
leading Lewis and Clark
across North America.

[Cleopatra . . .]
You will turn 18
and become queen of the Nile.

[Nelly Bly . . .]
You will turn 18
and bring justice to journalism.

[For Teenage Girls with Wild Ambitions and Trembling Hearts . . .]
You are now 18, standing on the precipice,
trembling before your own greatness.

This is your call to leap.

There will always being those
who say you are too young and delicate
to make anything happen for yourself.
They don't see the part of you that smolders.
Don't let their doubting drown out the sound
of your own heartbeat.

You are the first drop of a hurricane.
Your bravery builds beyond you. You are needed

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by all the little girls still living in secret,
writing oceans made of monsters and
throwing like lightening.

You don't need to grow up to find greatness.
You are stronger than the world has ever believed you to be.
The world laid out before you to set on fire.
All you have to do
is burn.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Clementine von Radics
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AWARD HISTORY

CO State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier